

OP9 Recognition and Celebration

Absorbs OP14b (Public Recognition for Informal Growth). Restructured from a program design guide into a team-driven recognition design exercise.

Pillar	Opportunity	Difficulty	Level 1
Time Required	35-45 minutes	Group Size	4-12
Mode	Team facilitation	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	None	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Lack of recognition for individual contributors, recognition only for leadership track, informal career growth going unnoticed, low morale signals

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

Recognition activates the brain's reward circuitry at multiple levels. Dopamine fires when recognition is received (reward). Serotonin activates when the recognition signals status and belonging (social standing). Oxytocin releases when recognition comes from someone trusted (connection). This triple activation is why recognition is one of the highest-leverage engagement tools available.

The brain is also sensitive to recognition patterns. If recognition only flows toward promotion-track employees, people who contribute through expertise, reliability, or collaboration without seeking leadership roles receive no neurochemical reward for their work. Over time, their engagement declines not because their work changed but because the reward signal stopped.

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Recognition Audit (8 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Quick check. In the last month, who on this team has been recognised for their contribution? By me, by each other, or by anyone else in the organisation. Let's be honest about who gets noticed and who doesn't."

Map it. The pattern usually reveals that recognition clusters around visible work (presentations, client wins, project completions) and misses invisible work (mentoring colleagues, maintaining systems, catching errors, supporting team members).

Phase 2: What Deserves Recognition (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"What contributions on this team go unrecognised? Not just unrecognised by me. Unrecognised by anyone. What work keeps this team functioning that nobody ever says thank you for?"

Build a list. Common items: the person who onboards new team members, the person who documents processes, the person who de-escalates tension, the person who catches quality issues, the person who maintains the team's tools. These contributions are essential but invisible.

Phase 3: Designing Recognition That Lands (15 minutes)

The team designs its own recognition approach. Two questions:

8. What kind of recognition do you personally find meaningful? (Public acknowledgment? Private thank-you? Specific feedback about impact? Tangible reward? More autonomy or opportunity?)
9. How can we make recognition a regular part of how we work rather than a special event?

Practical mechanisms the team can adopt:

- A 2-minute 'recognition round' at the start or end of weekly team meetings ("Who do you want to thank this week?")
- A shared Slack/Teams channel for specific recognition (not generic "great job" but "Thank you for [specific action] which resulted in [specific impact]")
- Manager commitment: at least one piece of specific recognition per team member per month, delivered in their preferred format

Phase 4: Immediate Practice (5 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"Let's start now. Each person, recognise one person on this team for a specific contribution from the past month. Be specific: what they did, and what impact it had."

Go round the room. The live practice makes the concept tangible and often produces genuine surprise and emotion.

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
Recognition round becomes generic ("Everyone's doing a great")	Push for specificity: "Thank you, but can you name one specific thing someone did this week that made a difference? The more specific, the more it means."

job")	
Someone is uncomfortable receiving public recognition	This is why Phase 3 asks about preferred format. Some people genuinely prefer private recognition. Respect that. Do not force public acknowledgment on someone who finds it uncomfortable.

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C15: Building a Feedback Culture	Recognition is one component of feedback culture. C15 provides the broader system; OP9 focuses specifically on positive recognition.	Complementary
V7: Reducing Fear of Failure	V7's recognition of risk-taking complements OP9's broader recognition framework. They should align.	Complementary
L9: Tracking Learning Progress	Recognising learning progress alongside work output sends the signal that development matters.	Complementary